



Trinity College Dublin
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Describing Meaning - Week 11: Tense and Aspect

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- **Pedagogically:** 12?

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Quine

“To be is to be the value of a bound variable.”

W. V. O. Quine

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Temporal relations

Temporal precedence and overlap

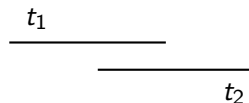
Precedence

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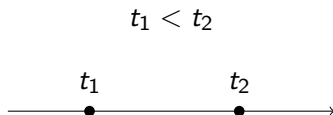
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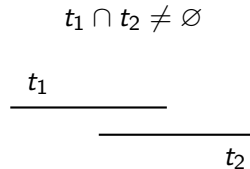


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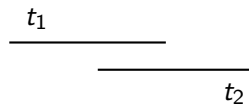
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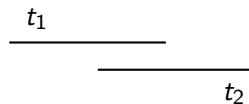
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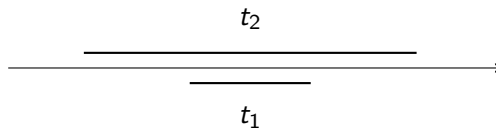


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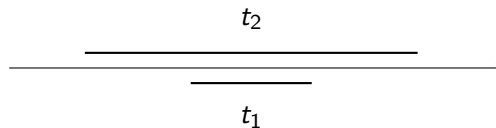
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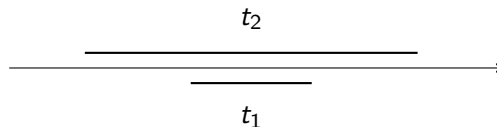


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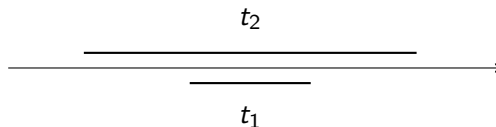


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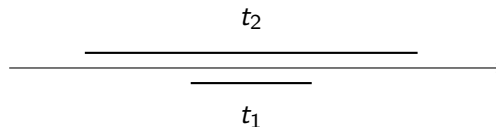


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- Klein's term **topic time** is a bit better because it captures the intuition that this is the time the sentence is "about".

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- Reichenbach's classic idea: tense interpretation involves three times.
- **Speech time (S)**: time of utterance.
- **Event time (E)**: time of the reported eventuality.
- **Reference time (R)**: a time used to locate the event.
- Klein's term **topic time** is a bit better because it captures the intuition that this is the time the sentence is "about".
- So I will mostly use **T** for what is sometimes called **R**

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English tense and aspect

Simple past

Tom walked Fiona.

Simple past

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Tense:

$$T < S$$

Simple past

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Tense:

$$T < S$$

Aspect:

$$E \subseteq T$$

Simple past

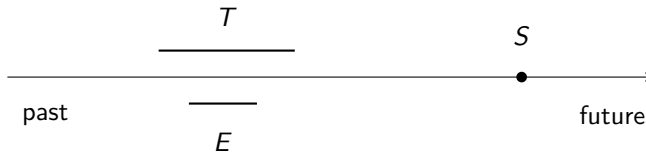
Tom walked Fiona.

Tense:

$$T < S$$

Aspect:

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Future

Fiona will roll over.

Future

Fiona will roll over.

Tense:

$$S < T$$

Future

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Aspect:

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